

[Lesson 39](#): “The Hearts of the Children Shall Turn to Their Fathers” (See L39 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand the need to seek out our ancestors and receive priesthood ordinances in their behalf.

†1. Frederick William Hurst’s journal entry [Pictures of our Church Presidents](#)

1. Elijah: “The keys of this dispensation are committed into your hands.”

• D&C 2:2; JS—History 1:39. “And he shall plant in the hearts of the children the promises made to the fathers”.

†2. President Joseph Fielding Smith †3. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland

• D&C 110:13-16; D&C 2. Elijah appeared to Joseph Smith and Oliver Cowdery in the Kirtland Temple on April 3, 1836. He spoke to them and restored the sealing power of the priesthood for eternal marriage and eternal families.

• JS—History 1:37-39; D&C 138:47-48.

Why would the earth be “utterly wasted at [the Lord’s] coming if we did not have the sealing power?

†4. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland

2. President Wilford Woodruff: “Somebody has got to redeem them.”

“President Woodruff was devoted to the work of redeeming the dead and sealing families for eternity. During his ministry, many members of the Church served genealogical missions, and in 1894 the First Presidency directed the organization of a genealogical society (*Our Heritage*, [page 101](#)). According to Elder Russell M. Nelson ... ‘events of that historic year [1894] established family history research and temple service as *one work* in the Church’” (“[The Spirit of Elijah](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 85).

The urgency of Temple work for the dead

Read the story of Bishop Henry Ballard and his daughter, *Our Heritage*, [page 99](#).

†5. President Wilford Woodruff Sister Atkinson stories

What can we learn from these stories? †6. President Wilford Woodruff

The need for us to be sealed to our parents and ancestors

President Wilford Woodruff’s revelation on genealogical work in *Our Heritage*, [page 101](#).

3. President Joseph F. Smith: “The eyes of my understanding were opened.”

†7. President Wilford Woodruff †8. About President Joseph F. Smith’s revelation of D&C 138

• D&C 138:1-11. “I sat in my room ‘pondering over the scriptures; And reflecting upon the great atoning sacrifice ...’”.

• D&C 138:12-19. Whom did the Savior visit in the spirit world? (Find five descriptions in verses 12-15.)

• D&C 138:20-21. To whom did the Savior not go?

• D&C 138:27-37, 57. From “among the righteous, he organized his forces”.

• D&C 138:57. The “faithful elders ... when they depart from mortal life, continue their ... preaching of the gospel”.

• D&C 138:22-24, 57-59. With the rebellious “darkness reigned, but among the righteous there was peace”.

“58 The dead who repent will be redeemed, through obedience to the ordinances of the house of God, and ...”.

How are those who have been faithful to the testimony of Jesus different from those who have not?

How do these verses make you feel about our personal responsibility to do work for the dead?

4. President Gordon B. Hinckley: “We are determined ... to take the temples to the people.”

President Joseph F. Smith prophesied about temples dotting the earth in *Our Heritage*, [page 106](#).

“President Hinckley ... has expanded our understanding of temple work. When he became President of the Church in 1995, there were 47 temples in operation. About two and one-half years later, he made the following announcement:” (*Lesson Manual*) †9. President Gordon B. Hinckley

“In April 1998, President Hinckley announced a goal to have 100 temples in operation by the end of the century” (see “[New Temples to Provide ‘Crowning Blessings’ of the Gospel](#),” *Ensign*, May 1998, 88). †10. President Gordon B. Hinckley

Next Week: L40: Finding Joy in Temple and Family History Work; See L40 [Class Member Study Guide](#).
(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. Frederick William Hurst: “Frederick William Hurst was working as a gold miner in Australia when he first heard Latter-day Saint missionaries preach the restored gospel. He and his brother Charles were baptized in January 1854. He tried to help his other family members become converted, but they rejected him and the truths he taught.

“Fred settled in Salt Lake City four years after joining the Church, and he served faithfully as a missionary in several different countries. He also worked as a painter in the Salt Lake Temple. In one of his final journal entries, he wrote:

“ ‘Along about the 1st of March, 1893, I found myself alone in the dining room, all had gone to bed. I was sitting at the table when to my great surprize [*sic*] my elder brother Alfred walked in and sat down opposite me at the table and smiled. I said to him (he looked so natural): “When did you arrive in Utah?”

“ ‘He said: “**I have just come from the Spirit World, this is not my body that you see, it is lying in the tomb.**” I want to tell you that when you were on your mission you told me many things about the Gospel, and the hereafter, and about the Spirit World being as real and tangible as the earth. I could not believe you, but when I died and went there and saw for myself I realized that you had told the truth. **I attended the Mormon meetings.**” He raised his hand and said with much warmth: “I believe in the Lord Jesus Christ with all my heart. I believe in faith, and repentance and baptism for the remission of sins, but that is as far as I can go. I look to you to do the work for me in the temple. ... You are watched closely. ... We are all looking to you as our head in this great work. I want to tell you that there are a great many spirits who weep and mourn because they have relatives in the Church here who are careless and are doing nothing for them””” (*Diary of Frederick William Hurst*, comp. Samuel H. and Ida Hurst [1961], 204 in the *Lesson Manual*).

†2. President Joseph Fielding Smith: “What was the promise made to the fathers that was to be fulfilled in the latter days by the turning of the hearts of the children to their fathers? It was the promise of the Lord made through Enoch, Isaiah, and the prophets, to the nations of the earth, that the time should come when the dead should be redeemed” (*Doctrines of Salvation*, comp. Bruce R. McConkie, 3 vols. [1954–56], 2:154).

†3. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland: “God made those promises to the ancient patriarchs—Adam, Noah, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and so forth—and we undoubtedly made them to our own lineal fathers and mothers, those who came to earth before the gospel was restored but whom we promised to provide its saving ordinances” (*Christ and the New Covenant* [1997], 297).

†4. Elder Jeffrey R. Holland taught that without the sealing power, “no family ties would exist in the eternities, and indeed the family of man would have been left in eternity with ‘neither root [ancestors] nor branch [descendants].’ Inasmuch as ... a sealed, united, celestially saved family of God is the ultimate purpose of mortality, any failure here would have been a curse indeed, rendering the entire plan of salvation ‘utterly wasted”’ (*Christ and the New Covenant*, 297–98).

†5. President Wilford Woodruff served for a time as “president of the temple in St. George, Utah. It was in that temple that endowments for the dead were performed for the first time in this dispensation (see *Doctrines of Salvation*, 2:171). While serving there, President Woodruff was visited by the spirits of many ‘eminent men’ who had died.” (*Lesson Manual*)

He said:

“The spirits of the dead gathered around me, wanting to know why we did not redeem them. Said they, ‘You have had the use of the Endowment House for a number of years, and yet nothing has ever been done for us. We laid the foundation of the government you now enjoy, and we ... remained true to it and were faithful to God.’ These were the signers of the Declaration of Independence [of the United States of America], and they waited on me for two days and two nights. ... I straightway went into the baptismal font and called upon Brother McAllister to baptize me for the signers of the Declaration of Independence, and fifty other eminent men, making one hundred in all, including John Wesley, Columbus, and others” (*The Discourses of Wilford Woodruff*, sel. G. Homer Durham [1946], 160–61).

†6. President Wilford Woodruff: “For the last eighteen hundred years, the people that have lived and passed away never heard the voice of an inspired man, never heard a Gospel sermon, until they entered the spirit-world. Somebody has got to redeem them, by performing such ordinances for them in the flesh as they cannot attend to themselves in the spirit, and in order that this work may be done, we must have Temples in which to do it” (in *Journal of Discourses*, 19:228–29).

Recommended reading:

1. Elder Russell M. Nelson, “[The Spirit of Elijah](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 85.

Visit stephenmbird.com

†7. **President Wilford Woodruff:** “President [Brigham] Young, who followed President Joseph Smith, ... laid the foundation of [the Salt Lake Temple], as well as others in the mountains of Israel. What for? That we might carry out these principles of redemption for the dead. He accomplished all that God required at his hands. But he did not receive all the revelations that belong to this work; neither did President [John] Taylor, nor has Wilford Woodruff” (*The Discourses of Wilford Woodruff*, 153–54).

†8. **About President Joseph F. Smith’s revelation of D&C 138:** “President Smith, the sixth President of the Church, received a revelation that helped the work of redeeming the dead continue to move forward. On 4 October 1918, just weeks before his death, he said in general conference:

“‘I have been undergoing a siege of very serious illness for the last five months.... I have not lived alone these five months. I have dwelt in the spirit of prayer, of supplication, of faith and of determination; and I have had my communication with the Spirit of the Lord continuously” (in Conference Report, [Oct. 1918](#), 2).

“The day before President Smith made this statement, he had received a revelation that would expand the Saints’ understanding of the redemption of the dead. This revelation is now section 138 of the Doctrine and Covenants. It is a record of the Savior’s visit to the spirit world while His body was in the tomb.” (*Lesson Manual*)

†9. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “There are many areas of the Church that are remote, where the membership is small and not likely to grow very much in the near future. Are those who live in these places to be denied forever the blessings of the temple ordinances? While visiting such an area a few months ago, we prayerfully pondered this question. The answer, we believe, came bright and clear.

“We will construct small temples in some of these areas, buildings with all of the facilities to administer all of the ordinances. They would be built to temple standards, which are much higher than meetinghouse standards. They would accommodate baptisms for the dead, the endowment service, sealings, and all other ordinances to be had in the Lord’s house for both the living and the dead. ...

“... We are determined ... to take the temples to the people and afford them every opportunity for the very precious blessings that come of temple worship” (“[Some Thoughts on Temples, Retention of Converts, and Missionary Service](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1997, 49–50).

†10. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “Accordingly, I take this opportunity to announce to the entire Church a program to construct some 30 smaller temples immediately. They will be in Europe, in Asia, in Australia and Fiji, in Mexico and Central and South America and Africa, as well as in the United States and Canada. They will have all the necessary facilities to provide the ordinances of the Lord’s house.

“This will be a tremendous undertaking. Nothing even approaching it has ever been tried before. These will be in addition to the 17 buildings now going forward in England; Spain; Ecuador; Bolivia; the Dominican Republic; Brazil; Colombia; Billings, Montana; Houston, Texas; Boston, Massachusetts; White Plains, New York; and Albuquerque, New Mexico; and the smaller temples in Anchorage, Alaska; Monticello, Utah; and Colonia Juárez, Mexico. This will make a total of 47 new temples in addition to the 51 now in operation. I think we had better add 2 more to make it an even 100 by the end of this century, being 2,000 years “since the coming of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ in the flesh” (D&C 20:1). In this program we are moving on a scale the like of which we have never seen before” (“[New Temples to Provide ‘Crowning Blessings’ of the Gospel](#),” *Ensign*, May 1988, 88).

Recommended media:

1. Video: [The Dead Awaited the Atonement](#) (0:34)

Further recommended reading:

1. President J. Grant, “[Comforting Manifestations](#),” *Improvement Era*, Feb. 1931, 189–190. (Read about Feramorz L. Young who died on his mission to Mexico and appeared in a dream to Horace G. Whitney, a close friend of President Grant’s. Note what he tells Horace. Also read the story about the beautiful young woman who came to his mother in a dream.)
2. [Nancy Jensen](#), at Gospel Doctrine Plus, in Lesson #39 retold the story of the Spanish Influenza and World War I, which were both raging at the time President Joseph F. Smith received D&C 138.
3. George S. Tate, “[I Saw the Hosts of the Dead](#),” *Ensign*, Dec. 2009, pp. 54–59.
4. Stephen D. Ricks, “[The Appearance of Elijah and Moses in the Kirtland Temple and the Jewish Passover](#),” *BYU Studies Quarterly*, 23:4.
5. George S. Tate, “[The Great World of the Spirits of the Dead](#)”: ... *BYU Studies Quarterly*, 46:1.

Visit stephenmbird.com